The Lighthouse Keepers of Saltmere

For more than a century the lighthouse on Saltmere Point was tended by a single family. The first keeper, a former ship's carpenter, arrived in 1871 with his wife and three children. He kept a detailed journal of the weather, the passing vessels and the condition of the great lamp. His descendants continued the journal without interruption until the light was automated in 1979.

The journal is now held by the county archive, where volunteers are transcribing it page by page. So far they have completed the entries for the first forty years. The work is slow, because the handwriting changes with every generation and the ink has faded in places. Even so, the transcriptions already reveal a remarkable record of local life.

Storms are described with particular care. In the winter of 1893 the keeper noted that waves reached the gallery for three consecutive nights. He spent those nights relighting the lamp and wiping salt from the windows. Shipwrecks are rarer than one might expect, and most entries record ordinary days of maintenance and quiet observation.

The archive plans an exhibition for next summer. Visitors will be able to read selected pages alongside photographs of the keepers and their families. A small committee is also collecting recollections from people who visited the lighthouse as children. Anyone with letters, pictures or stories about Saltmere Point is invited to contact the archive.

The organisers hope that the exhibition will encourage further research into the coastal history of the region. They also intend to publish the complete transcription online once the work is finished.

Funding for the project comes from a local trust and from the sale of a small illustrated guide. The guide describes the lighthouse, its equipment and the daily routine of the keepers. Copies are available at the archive and at the harbour office.